The Woman Who Walked Into Doors

By Roddy Doyle

**NOTE: Roddy Doyle is an Irish author and this would be the perfect piece to try out your Irish dialect.*

My name is Paula Spencer. I am thirty-nine years old. I was married for eighteen years. My husband left me. I threw him out. His name was Charles Spencer; everybody called him Charlo.

INTRODUCTION

In Ireland, the euphemism "she walked into a door" is so loaded with grim implications of domestic abuse that it is usually whispered, not spoken. According to Women's Aid of Ireland, one third of women never relate their experiences to anyone and simply try to survive – as well as to protect their children in many instances – as best they can on their own. – Many people ask . . . Why don't they just leave? And in Paula Spencer's story, perhaps we can understand exactly that. Why?? The Woman Who Walked into Doors by Roddy Doyle

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THE FIRST TIME IT HAPPENED . . . . . He lost his temper. And he hit me. It was as simple as that. He sent me flying across the kitchen. I hit the sink and fell. I felt nothing, only shock. And a spinning in my head. I knew nothing for a while, where I was, who was with me, how come I was on the floor. Then I saw his feet, then his legs, making a triangle with the floor. He seemed way up over me. Miles up. I had to bend back to see him. Then he came down to meet me.

CHARLO: Y'alright?

His eyes were going all over my face, every inch and corner. Looking, searching. Looking for marks, looking for blood. He was worried. His face was full of worry and love. He was scared.

CHARLO: You fell.

I didn't - I wouldn't do what he wanted, he was in his moods, I was being smart, he hated me being pregnant, I wasn't his little Paula any more - and he drew his fist back and he hit me. He wanted to hurt me. And he did. OR . . . . I'd been too near

him; he hadn't realised. He'd only been warning me. He didn't know his own strength. He had things on his mind. Anything. It wouldn't happen again. It had been a mistake. We'd laugh about it later. Remember the time. We **did** laugh about it later. That night. And the time after that. And the time after that. Many other nights. Until I couldn't laugh any more. I wouldn't let myself. Nothing came out when I opened my mouth. Only pain.

Someone once told me that we never remember pain. Once it's gone it's gone. A nurse. She told me just before the doctor put my arm back in its socket. She was being nice. She'd seen me before.

-I fell down the stairs again, I told her. No questions asked. What about the burn on my hand? The missing hair? The teeth? I waited to be asked. Ask me. Ask me. Ask me. I'd tell her. I'd tell them everything. Look at the burn. Ask me about it. Ask. . . . No.

The doctor never looked at me. He studied parts of me but he never saw all of me. He never

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looked at my eyes. Drink, he said to himself. I could see his nose moving, taking in the smell, deciding. I am an alcoholic. I've never admitted it to anyone. I've never done anything about it; I've never tried to stop. I think I could if I really wanted to, if I was ready. I've always liked a drink. I don't remember when I stopped liking it and started needing it. It crept up on me, I suppose.

Being hit by Charlo the first time knocked everything else out of me. One day I was Mrs Paula Spencer, a young wife and soon to be a mother, soon moving into a new house, in a new place, making my husband's dinner, timing it so it would be just ready for when he came in from work. Then I was on the floor and that was the end of my life. The future stopped rolling in front of me. Everything stopped.

I keep blaming myself. After all the years and the broken bones and teeth and torture I still keep on blaming myself. I can't help it. What if? What if? He wouldn't have hit me if I hadn't . . . none of

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the other fists and belts would have followed if I hadn't. . . He hit me, he hit his children, he hit other people - and I keep blaming myself. For provoking him. For not loving him enough; for not showing it. *Did you fall down the stairs, Paula? Did you walk into a door, Paula? What made him do that, Paula? What made* you *do that, Paula? Did you say something to him, Paula?* No. No. No! I'm innocent. I'm innocent. I'm innocent. He. Hit. Me. Ask me. Ask me. Ask me. Here goes.

Broken nose. Loose teeth. Cracked ribs. Broken finger. Black eyes. I don't know how many; I once had two at the same time, one fading, the other new. Shoulders, elbows, knees, wrists. Stitches in my mouth. Stitches on my chin. A ruptured eardrum. Burns. Cigarettes on my arms and legs. Thumped me, kicked me, pushed me, burned me. He butted me with his head. He held me still and butted me; I couldn't believe it. He dragged me around the house by my clothes and by my hair. He kicked me up and he kicked me down

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the stairs. Bruised me, scalded me, threatened me. For seventeen years. Hit me, thumped me, raped me. Seventeen years. He threw me into the garden. He threw me out of the attic. Fists, boots, knee, head. Bread knife, saucepan, brush. He tore out clumps of my hair. Cigarettes, lighter, ashtray. He set fire to my clothes. He locked me out and he locked me in. He hurt me and hurt me and hurt me. He killed parts of me. He killed most of me. He killed all of me. Bruised, burnt and broken. Bewitched, bothered and bewildered. Seventeen years of it. He never gave up. Months went by and nothing happened, but it was always there - the promise of it.

For seventeen years. There wasn't one minute when I wasn't afraid, when I wasn't waiting. Waiting for him to go, waiting for him to come. Waiting for the fist, waiting for the smile. I was brainwashed and braindead, a zombie for hours, afraid to think, afraid to stop, completely alone. I sat at home and waited. I mopped up my own blood.

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I lost all my friends, and most of my teeth. He gave me a choice, left or right; I chose left and he broke the little finger on my left hand. Because I scorched one of his shirts. Because his egg was too hard. Because the toilet seat was wet. Because because because. He demolished me. He destroyed me. And I never stopped loving him. I adored him when he stopped. I was grateful, so grateful, I'd have done anything for him. I loved him. And he loved me.

He was everything and I was nothing. I provoked him. I was stupid. I forgot. I needed him. I was hopeless, useless, good for nothing. I lived through years of my life thinking that they were the most important things about me, the only real things. I couldn't cope, I couldn't earn, I needed him. I needed him to show me the way; I needed him to punish me.

(FLASHBACK TO MEMORY)

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LEANNE: -Don't hit my mammy!

Leanne's voice. She is twelve [now – she was younger then . . . 5 or 6?] She always cheers me up. She's intelligent and creative and good at math. Leanne's arms around my leg, clinging to me. As he went around me. And I turned to keep facing him. Trying to keep Leanne behind me. -It's alright, love. To Leanne. Patting her head. Her face pushed into me. Looking at her father. Looking at his fists. At his face. Not being able to see her. My hand on her head. -It's okay. Having to keep my eyes on Charlo. Pleading with him, holding him back. Feeling Leanne's shivering. Keeping him back. Making sure I faced him. Making sure I didn't let her become a shield. Her heart beating. Keeping my eyes on Charlo's eyes.

CHARLO: -Where'd you get that?

PAULA: -What?

CHARLO: -The eye.

It was a test. I was thumping inside. He was playing with me. There was only one right answer. -

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I walked into the door.

CHARLO: -Is that right? Looks sore.

-It's not too bad. He was messing with me, playing. Like a cat with an injured bird. Keeping me in my place. Pretending he didn't remember. I could never fight back. When he wasn't hitting me he was reminding me that he could. He was reminding me and getting me ready. Like the cat playing with the bird, letting it live a bit longer before he killed it. He put one of his fingers on the bruise. I made sure I stayed absolutely still.

CHARLO: -You must have walked right into it, did you?

PAULA: -Yeah; I wasn't looking.

CHARLO: -Which door?

PAULA: -Bedroom.

CHARLO: -Were you drinking?

PAULA: -No. Just careless.

CHARLO: -Yeah.

Every day. I think about it every minute. Why did he do it? No real answers come back, no

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big Aha. He loved me. I know it. But if he loved me, why did he hit me? Why did he hit me so hard and so often? The questions are never answered. They always torment me. And his love becomes a cruel thing, like a smile on a Nazi's face. You don't hit the people you love. You might, once or twice - it's only human. But not the way he did it, again and again. You don't pull back their fingers till they snap. You don't wake them in the morning with a kick in the stomach. You don't hold their face over the chip pan and threaten to dump their head into the boiling fat. You don't beat them in front of their children. That's not love. You can't love someone one minute, then beat them, and then love them again once the blood has been washed off.

I never gave up. I always got up off the floor. I got between them and him. I made ends meet. I never gave up. I'm here. I picked myself up. I washed the blood off my face. I put on the kettle.

I came close. I wanted to die. I lay on the floor and felt death under it. It was warm and I

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wanted it. I never wanted to get up. I was broken; I wanted to melt. I didn't know who I was. All I knew was the pain. But I got up. I always got up. I had children. I had a husband. I limped around the rooms, tucking the children up in their beds. I hung out the washing with a broken finger. I drank gin. I made sandwiches for their lunches; thin slivers of ham around the edges to hide the nothing in the middle. I hid. I hid the pain, the bruises and the poverty.

I could never get past the door. There were too many things. Things I didn't have. Money, somewhere to go. Too many things. The kids. The schools. People seeing me. All of them stopped me. It was all black out there. -Where would you be without me? he said. I couldn't go. He'd come after me and kill me. And the kids. He said he'd never let me take them. I wasn't fit to look after them; I was an alcoholic and too stupid. He wouldn't let it happen; they'd be better off dead. He looked at me. He meant it. He smashed me against the

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door before I could open it. He hit my face off it. I waited for the glass to smash into me.

CHARLO: -I'll kill you; I'll kill you!

I could never go. I always stopped at the door. But when I saw him looking that way at Nicola, She is eighteen . . . when I saw his eyes. It wasn't the way men look at women - I could nearly have understood that. It was almost natural, something to be careful about. But it was sheer hate. It was clear in his face. He wanted to ruin her, to kill her. His own daughter. Because he could. There was evil in him. I wasn't going to pretend any more. Things were falling apart and it didn't matter. I looked at Nicola.. She looked at me. Yes, her face said; you're right, it's happening. She looked embarrassed and guilty. What did I do? her face said. I'm sorry. Help.

He started humming. The noise disgusted me. I grabbed the frying pan. He was looking straight at Nicola; he was going to make her get out of his way, rub against her. I could always tell

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when Charlo was about to move; his shoulders told you. They went before his legs. I hit him on the side of the head with the pan.

I knew I was angry now. I took aim this time. He tried to get up. I hit him on top of the head. I could have killed him; it didn't matter. He collapsed properly. I'd done something. - I saw him, I said. -Looking.

Nicola nodded. She shut the fridge door.

NICOLA: -Is he dead?

PAULA: -I hope so, I said. His head moved; I had to start again.

NICOLA: -Kill him

PAULA: -No, I said. -There's no need. She couldn't believe me. She thought I was being completely thick.

NICOLA: -He'll kill you now.

PAULA: -No, he won't, I said.

NICOLA: -He will.

I escorted him off the premises. Out the gate he went. He got away from me, down the path,

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away from us. Drenched and bloody and stooped over like a travelling rat. -Go away! He stood there. At the gate. The blood was still running out of his head, down into one of his eyes. The door behind me slammed. It was Nicola. -Go away, will yeh! Go away! And he did. I couldn't believe it. He did what I'd told him to. He walked away. His head still down. He said nothing at all. -Jesus- -He's gone.

NICOLA: -What now?

-God knows, I said. -But one thing's for certain. He's not coming back in here again. Her face said it: she'd heard it before. -He's not, I said. It was a great feeling for a while. I'd done something good.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Roddy Doyle
ISBN: 978-0140255126
Publisher: Penguin Books
Date (Month/Year): Jan 1997

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